Continental drift

19a

The shape of the continents as well as fossil evidence suggest that the continents were once joined together into one huge landmass about 250 million years ago. This huge landmass has been given the name Pangea. About 135 million years ago the northern section, named Laurasia, and the southern section, called Gondwana, are believed to have separated. Geologists believe that by about 70 million years ago Gondwana had broken up to form the continents Australia, Africa, India, South America and Antarctica.

Rebuilding Gondwana

a Label the continents making up Gondwana below.

b Read the descriptions of the fossils on the next page. Design a key for each fossil mentioned and mark the fossils on the continents below.

c Cut out the continents and try to arrange them as they would have appeared about 135 million years ago. Use the shape of the continents and the fossils that you have marked on the continents to help you.

Fossil key

Symbol	Name
☐	
☐	
☐	
☐	

Continents that made up Gondwana



d Complete this sentence: It is possible to rebuild Gondwana because _____

_____

2 The following information has been written in point form. Rewrite the information into text using complete sentences and paragraphs.

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Continental drift

19b

Describing Gondwana fossils

Notes	Text
Cynognathus ■ Reptile ■ Skull and teeth look very dog-like ■ May have fed on other reptiles ■ Fossils dated about 240 million years ago ■ Fossils found in Southern Africa and South America	
Lystrosaurus ■ Reptile ■ About 75 cm long ■ Tortoise-like beak with 2 tusk-like teeth ■ Grazed on plants ■ Fossils date to about 240 million years ago ■ Fossil remains found in Central Antarctica, Southern Africa and Southern India	
Mesosaurs ■ Reptile ■ Semi-aquatic, about 40 cm long ■ Flexible tail, webbed feet ■ Efficient swimmer ■ Ate fish ■ Fossils dated about 240 million years ago ■ Fossils found in southern tip of Africa and South America	
Glossopteris ■ Plant ■ Primitive, seed bearing ■ Height of about 10 metres ■ Thick woody trunk ■ Large number of fossil leaves found ■ Fossils dated to about 250 million years ago ■ Fossils found in Southern Africa and India, Madagascar, Southern South America, Eastern Australia and Central Antarctica.	

3 Using the notes about the fossils, draw what you think the organisms may have looked like in the spaces provided below.

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